1.2 Defining Geography

Geography is one of the oldest earth sciences and its roots date back to the works of the early Greek scholars. The term '**Geography**' was coined by the Greek scholar **Eratosthenes** who combined two Greek words 'Geo' (The Earth) and 'Graphien' (to describe). Therefore, in the literary sense, geography is the description of the Earth. Over the ages, geography has become the art and science of studying the physical characteristics of the earth and man's role in adapting to and modifying the environment.

Geography was born through explorations and discoveries. Earlier, the aim of geography was to discover new lands, sea routes, prepare maps and describe them. Later, its emphasis had shifted to scientific investigation of earth's landforms, oceans and atmosphere, as well as the interactions with human beings and the environment.

In essence, geography can be defined as

- A multifaceted discipline
- Studying intra and inter relationships of various spheres of the earth
- Collects and analyses relevant data, applies the latest tools and methods to prepare maps and visuals
- Provides sustainable solutions to human and environmental issues of the earth.

1.3 Evolution of Geography

Ancient Greek scholars who laid the foundations and gave a solid form to geographic studies and on these foundations, the pillars of modern geography were erected by others in the subsequent ages. The Romans, the Arabs, the Indians, the Chinese, the Germans, the French, the British and the American geographers have contributed to the development and enrichment of the subject.

The Greek philosophers and scientist focused on the spatial nature of human and physical features of the Earth. The first Greek geographer was Herodotus (484 - 425 BCE) who wrote a number of volumes on the human and physical geography of the Persian Empire. The other early Greek contributors to geography are, Thales, Aristotle and Eratosthenes (276 - 194 BCE).

Geographers study the location of the activities, carefully identify patterns using maps and find out the reasons for these patterns. The areas are then described based on the distribution of land forms, population, housing and agriculture.

The development of geography can be summarised in three phases namely (1) The age of discovery (1400-1800), (2) The period between 1800 and 1950 and (3) The period after 1950.

1.3.1 The age of discovery between 1400-1800

The period between 1400 and 1800 was when the subject matter and the methodology of geography were not fully developed. This period was characterised by exploration, discovery and conquest through the voyages of Vasco da Gama and Christopher Columbus. Numerous journeys of geographical exploration were commissioned by a number of Nations in Europe (Figure. 1.1, 1.2, 1.3 and 1.4). Most of these voyages were financed because of the potential commercial returns from resource exploitation. The voyages also provided an opportunity for scientific investigation and discovery. Making of maps (cartography) was

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